


ANI

Q+A

# MASTERLY MOVES

**Women's World Rapid Chess champion KONERU HUMPY on her win and what lies ahead**

**Q. How did the year pan out for you before the World Rapid Chess Championship?**

I had a bad start to the Candidates in April 2024, but bounced back to finish second. But then I didn't do well at the Norway Chess and wanted to quit professional chess. The Tata Steel Chess tournament in November wasn't any better. But I had come really close to winning gold in the World Rapid Chess in 2023, losing only in the tie-break. So I felt I should give it one more shot.

**Q. How did you prepare for the World Rapid Chess?**

I don't use chess engines as much, nor do I prepare for openings. I play online games and solve a lot of puzzles, while also following videos of previous world champions to memorise the techniques. And I work on my mental attitude as well.

**Q. What does your daughter, Ahana, think of you travelling extensively to play tournaments?**

She misses me a lot and the first question when I get back is whether I am going for any other tournament. And if I am, she won't go to anyone else for a few days. But she also understands what I do. Once I went as a guest at her school's annual day and she asked me, 'They invited you because you play chess, right?'

**Q. Your next tournament and goals for 2025?**

I will be playing the FIDE Women's Grand Prix from April 13 in Pune and, later, the Norway Chess in May. My goal this year is to improve my classical rating.

**-with Shail Desai**